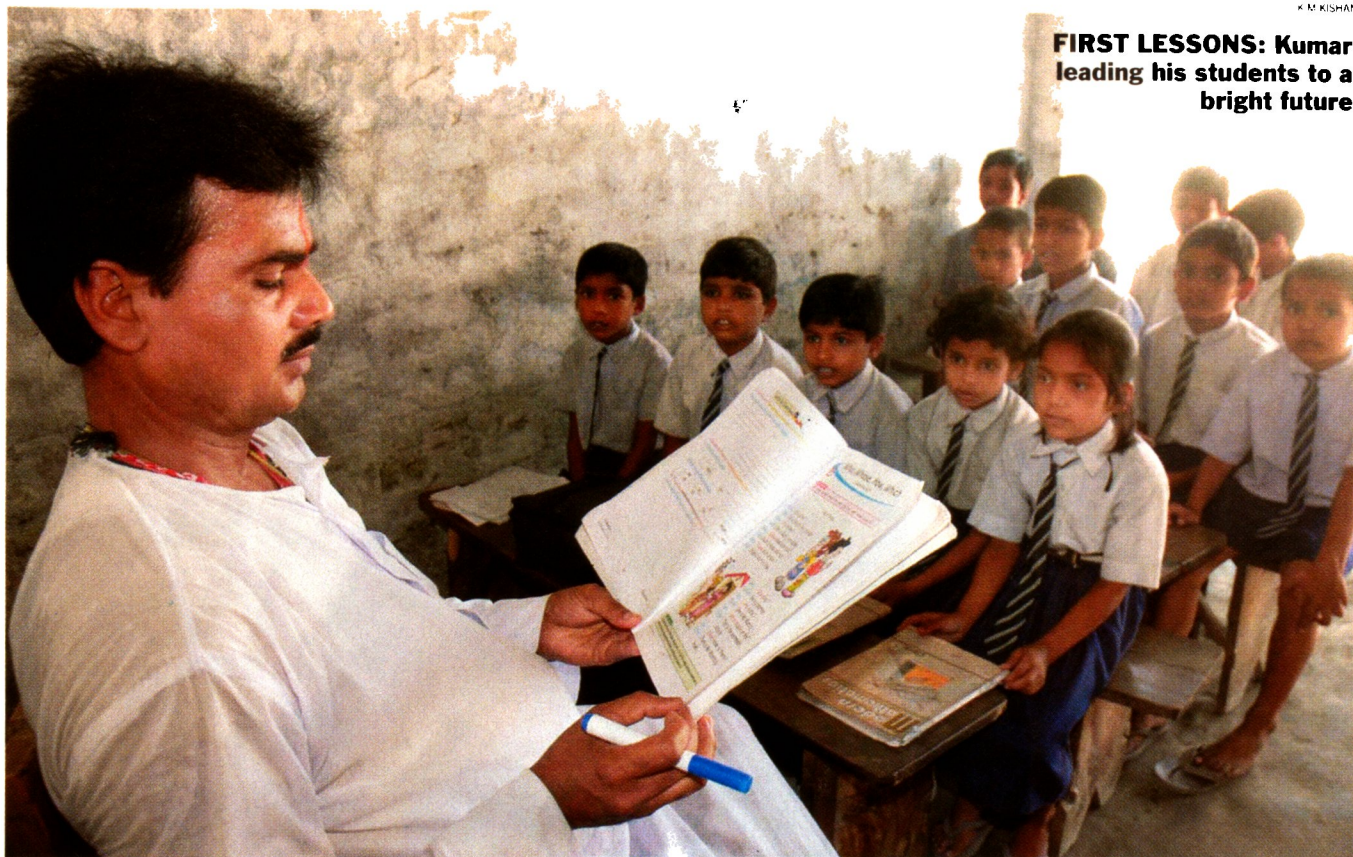




FIRST LESSONS: Kumar leading his students to a bright future

A Lifeterm Less Ordinary

New beginnings are in store for an ex-convict and his young students at his elementary school

■ **By Amitabh Srivastava**

At a glance, 46-year-old Deepak Kumar seems assured and focussed. He has become what he always wanted to be—a teacher. One who brings a benign smile on the pale faces of hundreds of children who study in his school in Vaishali district.

It is hard to believe that Kumar is a murder convict. He has served a 14-year jail sentence for killing an influential co-villager over a property dispute in June 1991. A final year post-graduate student then, he shot the man twice and was sentenced to 20 years of rigorous imprisonment. This was later commuted to 14 years as a result of his good conduct. Kumar, who was released in July 2005, returned to his village as a resolute man on a mission. "I decided to set up a school for deprived children of my village and neighbouring areas," he says.

Initially, it was not as easy as ABC. The bank officials, who visited the jail and promised support to the prisoners who wished to start life afresh after release, rejected his loan applications and the district officials too—contrary to earlier claims—offered no help. "I was back to square one. The stigma of being a murderer was following me everywhere," he recalls. Soon destiny yielded and a group of villagers,



friends and relatives rose in unison and extended their help. Some put in money, while others chipped in with construction material and a villager offered him land. Five months later his dream school was built.

Today, Kumar's residential, 15-roomed English-medium Deendayal Kushepremi Central School up to Class VII has eight teachers and more than 365 students—most of whom are poor and attend classes for a fee of Rs 75 per month—on its roll. A few parents have even decided to avail the school's hostel facilities for their children for a fee of Rs 600 per month.

Kumar owes all this to a benevolent jailer, Manoj Kumar Sinha, who led him to this vision. "He made me think and regret my crime. I started spending long hours in the jail library. He also had me teaching fellow prisoners and juvenile delinquents at the intermediate college in a Muzaffarpur jail," he says. He counts his wife, Priyanka, as his biggest support: "We were married for only six months when I was arrested. And she waited for 14 years. Now, we have a one-year-old son. And it's a race against time as I want to achieve a lot before I'm too old. It worries me that when he is 15, I will be 60."

There can, indeed, be life after a lifeterm and Kumar is a living example. ■